hypermedia open center

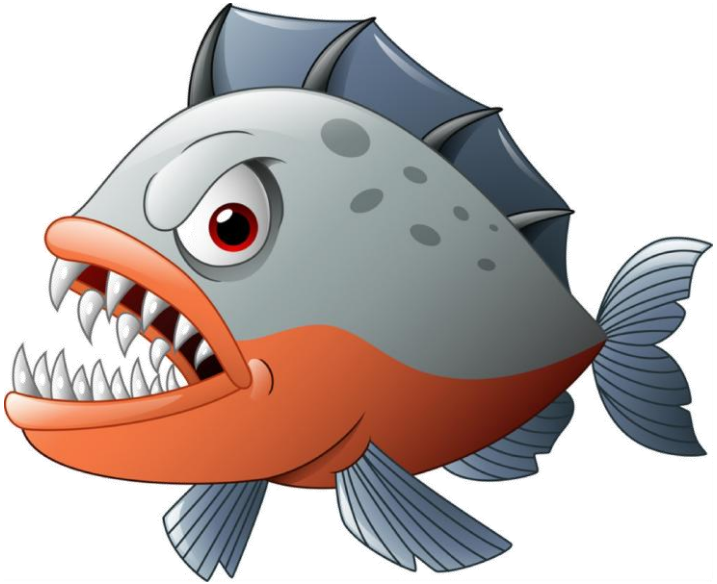
GRANT-WRITING

Nicoletta Di Blas

Innovation’s impact

…Fiddler’s vision of technical innovation as an ecosystem

When something “new”, like an invention, enters society, the whole ecosystem gets re-defined



ASK YOURSELF SOME QUESTIONS:

1. what **KIND OF FISH** do you want to be?

2. why does the pond need you? What is the **PAIN** you solve?

3. what **CRITICAL ASPECTS** will your introduction in the pond bring about? Do you have any idea about how to cope with them?

4. how will the pond change, after you are in and active? What kind of **BENEFITS** are you going to bring?

5 perceived attributes

…that favor the spread of an innovation

RELATIVE ADVANTAGE

- **Relative advantage:** an innovation must show that it is superior to what is already being used

- **Ask yourself the question**:
- “what is the relative advantage my idea is putting forth?”
- Make a list!

Rogers, E. M. (1962). *Diffusion of innovations*. Simon and Schuster.

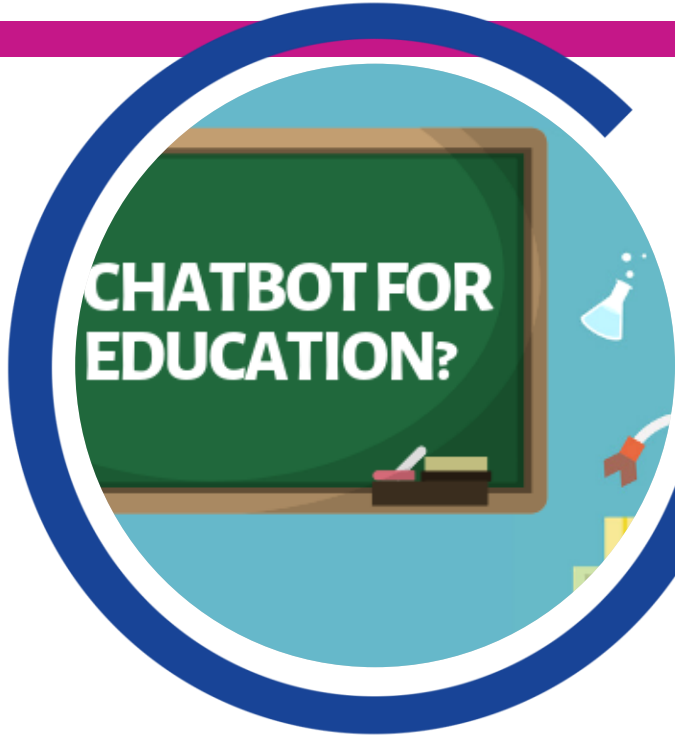
COMPATIBILITY

- **Compatibility:** the innovation must be perceived as compatible with the context (legal aspects, social habits…) in which it will be adopted

- **Ask yourself the question**:
- “is my idea compatible with the context?”
- Find mitigations or solutions for those aspects that are not

COMPLEXITY

- **Complexity:** the more an innovation is perceived as easy to use, the more it will have hope of being adopted
- **Ask yourself the question**:
- “is the product or service or tool that I want to make too complex?”
- Find mitigations or solutions; plan training



TRIALABILITY

- **Trialability:** if an innovation is “take it or leave it”, the probability of being adopted is significantly reduced
- **Ask yourself the question**:
- “is the product or service or tool that I am proposing something that can be tried?”
- Find mitigations or solutions

OBSERVABILITY

- **Observability:** the more visible the positive results of an innovation are, the faster its adoption will be
- **Ask yourself the question**:
- “is the product or service or tool that I want to make going to be visible, some way or another?”

3 MORE ATTRIBUTES (R. Fidler)

- **Social pressure:** sensitivity for environmental issues
- **Economic conditions:** bikes need to be affordable
- **Political influence:** policies for bikeways, tax savings for bike-buyers…

Fidler R., (1997) Mediamorphosis. Understanding new media, Pine Forge Press, c/o Sage Publications, Thousand Oaks (Ca).

Kinds of proposal

- Market-oriented proposals (e.g. for a start-up)
- Research-oriented proposals (e.g. EU calls)
- Different key values!
  - the case of **market-oriented** proposals: "**feasibility**". "This can be done, this is going to work and provide a return of investment" – the innovation component is not (so) crucial
  - in the case of **research-oriented** proposals: "**innovativeness**". "This is new, this has never been done before"

Main parts/1

- Most of the times, a structure is provided by the funding agency: it is fundamental to follow it
- But no matter what the structure is, you are bound to deal with:
  - The executive summary
  - The «starting point»
  - The state of the art

Main parts/2

- The **bulk** of the proposal, where you explain your overall **goal** and the specific objectives, followed by the **method**
  - A good goal is not enough, you need to show that you have a sound method to achieve it as well
- a reasonable **timeline** of the activities, which conveys the idea of feasibility
- information on the **proponents** (yourself and other partners, if any)
- The budget (costs of the project)

The executive summary

I apologize for sending such a long letter but I didn't have enough time to make it short

Executive summary and Abstract

- Both are quite condensed texts “summing up” a longer text. But there are differences:
- An abstract is a brief summary of a document, such as a journal article, a conference paper, a book proposal. It is usually 100-300 words long
- An executive summary is a summary of a longer document; max length: 10% of the document

Both should be:

- SHORT
- CLEAR (of course)
- COMPREHENSIVE (sketch the whole picture)
  - the context
  - the goal of the work (AND its relevance!)
  - [the method – if there is room]
  - the main results
- EFFECTIVE: convey the key-message(s) and values
- SELF-SUFFICIENT: never ever «point» to the main document; and yes, you can copy and paste from the main document

“This project addresses the issue of ageing population in Europe.” (ISSUE)

“The overall aim of the project is to prevent Mild Cognitive Impairment and Frailty.” (AIM)

“…by unobtrusive detection of data through sensors” (METHOD)

“… and exploiting data that smart cities are already collecting”. (METHOD – and KEY MESSAGE!)

“Detecting mild cognitive impairment and frailty will be partially automated, thus making the monitoring of the elderly population much more efficient and the prevention of frailty more effective” (BENEFIT)

Sketching a summary…

How should they NOT be?

- An introduction
  - An appetizer without the main course: “This is thesis is about conversational agents for people suffering from autism, which is a disease… bla bla… and… NOTHING ABOUT WHAT HAS BEEN DONE”
- A “table of content”
  - A skeleton without meat: “In the document we will discuss… then the method is introduced… then we will present the results…”

Main parts of a proposal

1
iPod
Phone
Internet

2

3

4

Different kinds of starting points

- An opportunity
- A gap (esp. in research)
- A pain/problem
- An issue (e.g. a social issue)
- … a good idea!

NEANDERTHAL MAN'S LACK OF CURIOSITY DOOMED HIM TO EXTINCTION

The goal

- The goal is what you mean to achieve
- You usually have ONE big goal, two at most
- Make the RELEVANCE clear
- Warning: don’t mix up the goal and the method (what you mean to do)
  - The aim of our project ‘Design and Application of Indoor Tracking System for Public Transportation’ is tracking the occupancy of vehicles and stations in Milan and extracting collected data to an application for users to plan their trip in an efficient way and for the company to better manage transportation system

The “state of the art”

- What is “out there” in the field of interest
- In a start-up proposal:
  - It would mean to identify (also) COMPETITORS
  - the point would be: there is room for us. Either what we want to do is completely new or similar to something else (but new under some respect)

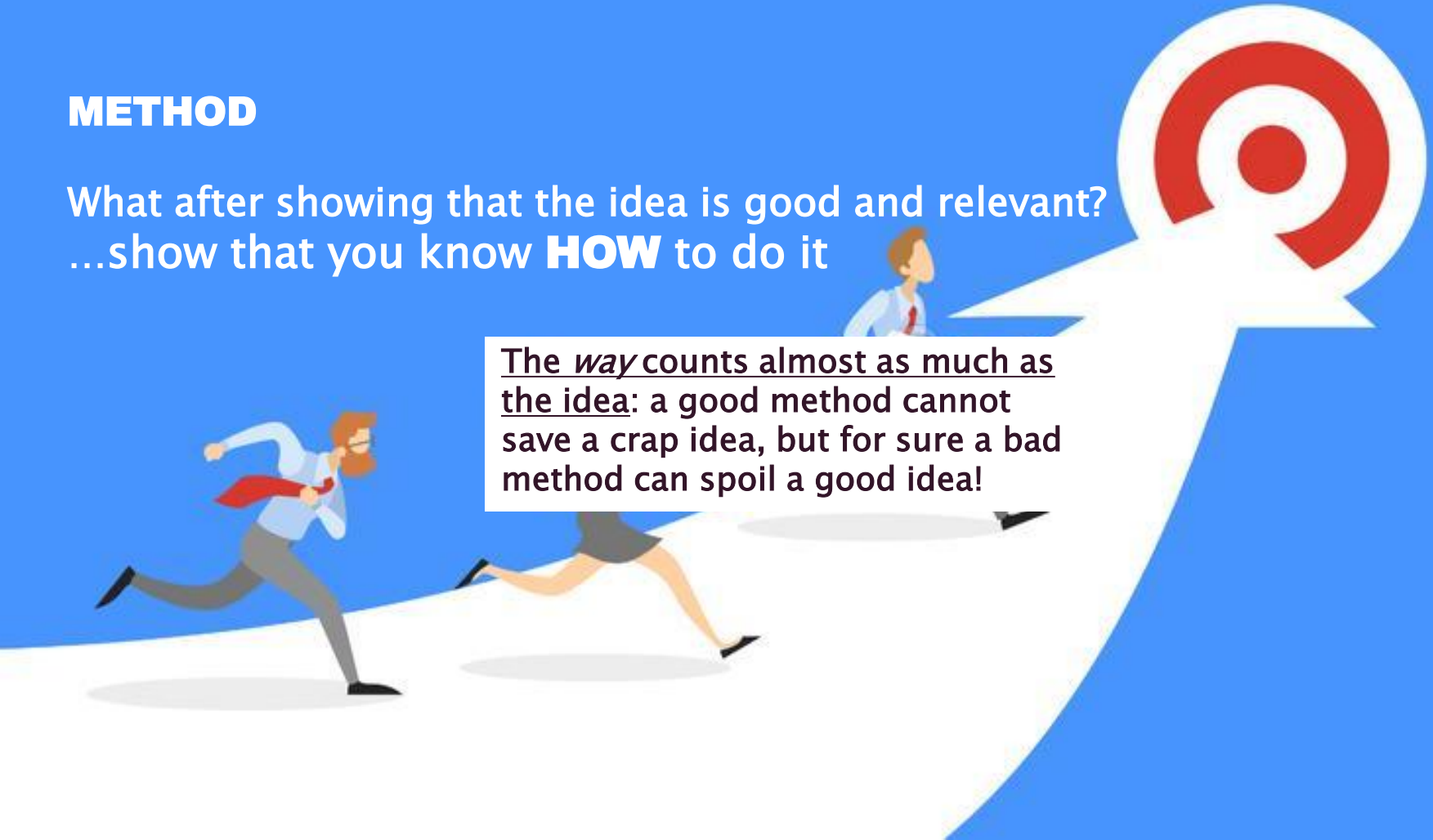
Market-oriented proposals need to reassure the reviewer about their feasibility, so there will be nothing wrong if the state of the art shows you are not fully innovative

The “state of the art”/2

- In the case of a **research-oriented proposal**, the summing-up of the state of the art must lead to this conclusion: that although a lot of valuable work has already been done, **something is still <u>unexplored</u>**

METHOD

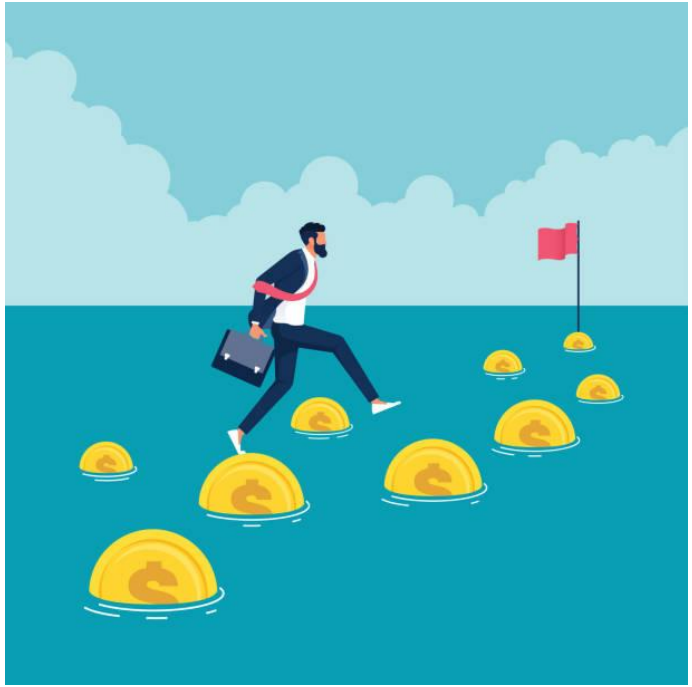
What after showing that the idea is good and relevant?
…show that you know **HOW** to do it



The *way* counts almost as much as the idea: a good method cannot save a crap idea, but for sure a bad method can spoil a good idea!

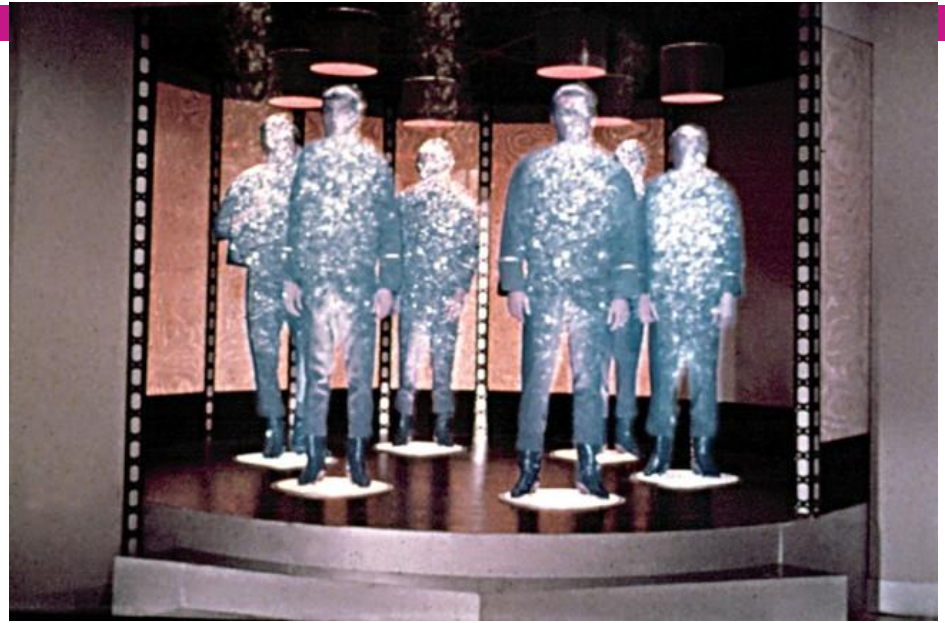
The plan

- Split the main task into smaller ones
- Be specific about:
  - What you will do
  - When
  - How
  - … number and quantities!



Work “backward”

- Feasibility: is also conveyed by the temporal plan
- Don’t think about the “ideal” plan
- **Take the time you are given and do your best with it**



Resources/1

- Same reasoning as for the plan
- Don't' make the "ideal budget"
- **Adjust your plan to the budget you can get** (also because… you cant' do otherwise)

Resources/2

- fit the proposal into the **available budget**
- pay attention to the **“value for money”. Don’t ask too much for doing too little** (you would look greedy). On the other hand, **don’t ask too little for doing a lot**
- remember to **make the operational plan consistent with the budget**. Remember that **human resources** are usually the highest cost. Are you planning enough human resources to do what you mean to do?

The proponents

- The last part is about YOU (if the proposal is not anonymous)
  - As an individual researcher
  - As a brilliant team/research group
  - As a consortium
- Select from your track records the **elements that are most relevant for the proposal** and the success criteria of the call you are answering to. Show that you have experience (FIT THE CALL!)

The reviewer’s work

Success criteria

- The reviewer has a clear list of success criteria to consider
- Most of the times, these same criteria are explicit/known
- Show, in writing your proposal, in what sense and to what extent you comply with them
- Be explicit, use the same words of the call

Tips/1

- You may try to “**write your own review**” when writing the proposal
- You can **highlight in bold all the crucial sentences** where the reviewer can find the answers to the form she’s supposed to fill in in evaluating your proposal
- You can list the crucial elements in a table or in a **bullet-point list**

Tips/2

- Put the “burden of proof” on the reviewer
- Example: let us imagine that one of the success criteria is “**originality**”
- You can say: “**my project is original under these two respects**”
- **Now, if the reviewer wants to object, he needs to prove you wrong**
- If you have not made any statements and hoped that the originality was self-evident, it is easier for the reviewer to say that you are not original

How does the reviewer read?

- Not from the first to the last page!
- The reviewer will start from the executive summary (and she might even stop there, if the summary is really bad and the competition is very high)
- Then: who the proponents are, then more in depth (description, outputs…)… then the budget
- Identify your strong points and don't' be afraid to **repeat** them more than once.

Some parts are more relevant

- The proponents: the reviewer needs to make sure that you can actually do what you promise
- State of the art:

1. **Research-oriented** proposal: the state of the art needs to be there and needs to exude scientific credibility, but quite rarely will it be read in details, as is more likely to happen in the case of a scientific paper.
2. **Market-oriented** proposal: the state of the art will probably be called in different ways and be more relevant. It will have to explain what place or niche the new product or the new service/idea will occupy. You have to be quite convincing on the fact that you have carefully scavenged the market or the field and there is room for you

Further tips

Writing strategy

- Option 1: «spiral»
  - Develop all the relevant subjects, one by one, in a concise manner
  - Then take one subject at a time and develop it in details
- Option 2: «waterfall»
  - Take one subject at the time and develop it in details

More on the spiral strategy

- List all the sections of the proposal
- Decide where to place the key messages (more than one place)
- Sketch the content for each section, in a raw manned
- Plan the connections among the various parts
  - E.g. if you have 3 objectives, make sure they are dealt with in the method and in the outcomes as well
- Make a second round, adding more details
- If more partners are involved, dispatch the plan and assign roles for the writing
  - This way, everyone is on the same page about what to say and about what the others will say (not obvious, especially for bulky proposals!)
- Make another round of reading of the whole proposal
  - Harmonize style and content
- Have someone ELSE do the final reading

END